attempted outreach to the United States. In the early 1990s, several factors converged: the initiation of a renewed Israel–Palestine peace process, India's defence requirements after the collapse of the Soviet Union, China's decision to start diplomatic ties with Israel, and the Organisation of Islamic Cooperation's vocal support for Pakistan in the Jammu and Kashmir dispute. During Palestinian leader Yasser Arafat's visit to India in 1991, he made it clear that they did not object to India's normalization of ties with Israel, an argument used by proponents such as Rao to counter sceptics in the Indian government, such as the minister Arjun Singh. India's decision to establish diplomatic ties with Israel was made on 29 January 1992. [10]

Not coincidentally, the Indian opening of relations with Southeast Asia and Israel also facilitated an improvement of ties with the United States at this time. In the early 1990s, the US Army's Pacific commander, Lt Gen. Claude M. Kicklighter, proposed to explore tentative military-to-military cooperation. In 1994, Rao visited the United States, with the tone and context now considerably different from past prime ministerial visits. In 1995, the Indian Air Force chief visited Washington, and two years later, the vice chairman of the US joint chiefs of staff reciprocated, marking the senior-most US military staff visit to India since 1953. US First Lady Hillary Clinton's 1995 trip to India was meant to pave the way for a presidential visit later. But the India-US relationship was hindered by two factors during this period: one was India's nuclear weapon programme and New Delhi's refusal to sign the nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT); the second was the Clinton administration's propensity to regard India and Pakistan as a problem to be solved like the Balkans, Israel–Palestine dispute, or Northern Ireland. Furthermore, urgent issues often took priority for Washington. As US Deputy Secretary of State Strobe Talbott later lamented, 'the Clinton administration paid less attention to [India] during its first six years in office than the president wanted'. [11]

The post-Cold War situation was also more auspicious for an altered Indian relationship with China. In 1992, Rao authorized a Border Peace and Tranquillity Agreement with China, which was signed in September 1993. China appeared keener to stabilize the border with India following the